turned to look at my father. His handlebar moustache, a style he had sported back when I was a child, had given way to a simple chevron above his thin lips over the years. I could not recollect if it had been a sudden and deliberate change, or merely a trick of age. It still added to the overall charm of his long, chiselled face. His round black eyes had sunk deeper now and his face looked more weather-beaten than I remembered. Drops of sweat had settled on the contours of his long, straight nose and above his thin, stretched brows. There were two or more wrinkles under his chin that I hadn't spotted earlier. Even when his moderately long hair, swept back on his head, and the shorter hair on the sides, wasn't entirely black any more, there was no change in his commanding personality as he stood tall in front of me.

Dark patches of sweat had formed on his khaki shirt, which he was wearing with black bell-bottomed trousers, but he seemed as excited as he had been on the day I had received a call letter for the SSB (Services Selection Board). I remember how he had jumped up in excitement and hugged me. I remember how he had marked the dates on the calendar and noted instructions mentioned in the letter in his pocket diary. I remember how he had rushed to Avadi railway station to book a ticket for me to Mysore, how he had carefully collected items I would require for my SSB exam, how he had ensured I had packed everything according to the checklist. To me, getting recommended in the SSB meant a chance at a glorious career. To him, it was validation of his relentless efforts in bringing me up the way he had. To make sure I would not miss my train, he had rung up the railway enquiry office every few minutes that morning to confirm whether the train was on time. Back in those days, we did not have the luxury of checking a train's running status on the Internet. It was an analogue world, crisscrossed with wires and cables; the label 'wireless' was still struggling to find its place. And I was struggling to hide my nervousness from Papaji.

'You seem worried, Gunju, but remember what I've always told you, all these twenty years of your life,' he said, as he pulled a handkerchief from his pocket, wiping the beads of sweat off my face. 'Just be who you are. No